

Control Which Pages Google Sends Your Paid Clicks To

Google's AI Max reads the intent, writes the ad, and picks the landing page on *your* site. This is the audit-and-exclusion pass to run before the window shuts. | Source: **Lisa Raehsler**, **Big Click Co**, on **Unscripted SEO** with Jeremy Rivera.

OBJECTIVE

Produce a written, maintained decision about every page on your site that could receive a paid click - which pages are fair game, which are excluded, and which campaigns opt out of automatic landing-page selection altogether - and get it entered in the account before the mandatory rollout. Budget one day for the inventory and the sort, plus an hour in the account.

There is a real deadline. Some features already flipped over and can still be opted out of today. A larger set becomes **mandatory in February**. "The plan has to roll out quickly." - Lisa Raehsler

KEY STEPS

- Calendar both dates first.** Part of this already happened; the February batch removes the choice. Everything below has to land inside that window.
- Run Google's own extraction as a free diagnostic.** Start a campaign from your site URL alone and read the keywords and ad copy it generates. Generic output is a verdict on your pages, not the tool. Do not launch it. (*Raehsler ran this; the standing-audit framing is ours.*)
- Inventory every page that could receive a paid click.** Crawl the whole indexed surface, not just the URLs your campaigns point at today - the engine chooses off your site, not off your ad group.
- Sort into allowed and excluded, and record why.** Privacy, about-us, careers, thin and stale pages go on the exclusion side. "You would really need to have a strategy as to what you would tell it to exclude... So now the human's entering those exclusions in."
- Flag every destination that is not a normal indexed page.** Third-party landing-page builders, deliberately unindexed PPC-only pages, and priced or seasonal variants all break under automatic selection. "If you were using that kind of tool, you would need to opt out of the automatic landing pages for sure."
- Enter the exclusions and lock the final URLs.** Uncheck automatic landing pages on the campaigns from step 5; enter page exclusions on the ones that stay automatic. Copy control and destination control are separate - you can keep the ad writing and still pin the page.
- Triage the rest of the AI Max feature list.** Sort every capability into fine as-is / worth an experiment / needs a human / opt out. Keep it as a document, the way Raehsler keeps her spreadsheet of features and controls.
- Re-check after site changes.** A page published next month inherits no exclusion, so a list entered once and forgotten degrades as the site grows. (*inferred: the cadence is ours, the "a human has to think it through" is hers.*)

CAUTIONARY NOTES

- **Doing nothing is a decision Google makes for you.** "You definitely don't want to do nothing."
- **Automatic selection genuinely works for some.** Good for e-commerce with clear, optimized pages; she cited movie and theater sites too. This is not a blanket opt-out.
- **It hurts most where nobody will notice.** Thin sites, under-resourced teams, and B2B specifically.
- **AI Max is search ads only.** Not Shopping, not display, not Local Service Ads (LSAs are separately migrating into Google Ads).
- **Manual override is permanent labor.** Priced variants have to be overridden by hand, per campaign, ongoing.
- **Excluding a weak page does not fix it.** Step 2 tells you which pages are actually unclear.

TIPS FOR EFFICIENCY

- Start the exclusion list with pages that convert nothing anywhere - privacy, terms, careers, about, author archives, thin tag pages. That is most of it in twenty minutes.
- Do it as one pass with the SEO team, not two passes in two departments. The page work counts for both channels.
- Keep the exclusions in a shared document that mirrors the account. Whoever inherits the campaign needs the reasoning, not just the setting.
- Re-run the step 2 extraction quarterly. Every wrong answer is a page-clarity bug with a URL attached.
- Handle third-party and unindexed landing pages first - those break loudly. An exclusion miss on a blog post just leaks budget quietly.

SOURCE

Lisa Raehsler, founder and principal SEM strategist at **Big Click Co** (bigclickco.com), VIP contributor at Search Engine Journal and host of *AI Ads & Beyond*. She framed AI Max not as a keyword change but as a destination change, which is why the exclusion strategy is the human work that survives it. Heard on **Unscripted SEO** with Jeremy Rivera: "Another Tuesday of Google Taking Control."

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